marne diya tha yaar tumlog?’ (How could you allow him to score a hundred?) He did play well, though, and took some calculated risks that paid off.

When I went in to bat in the afternoon of day two, I couldn’t time the ball to save my life. I just didn’t feel comfortable, so I decided to change my stance. This was something I used to try from time to time and it often did the trick. Normally I bat with a side-on stance, but in Hamilton I opened myself up slightly and also increased the gap between my feet a little. The umpire Simon Taufel noticed the difference and mentioned to me that I looked a completely different batsman after the drinks break and asked what I had done to myself. Sometimes such tiny adjustments can make a big difference.

Towards the end of the first day, the light dropped appreciably and Iain O’Brien, New Zealand’s best bowler in the series, was bowling from one end. The umpires were reluctant to stop the game, which I thought was unfair because it was a crucial time in the match and there was no chance of the light improving. I somehow managed to survive, though, and was unbeaten on 70 at the end of the second day. The next morning I got off to an aggressive start. My knock of 160 contributed to a sizeable first-innings lead, alongside fifties from Gambhir, Dravid and Zaheer Khan. Our bowlers, led by Bhajji with six wickets, delivered once again to set up a very satisfying win.

Unfortunately, I missed the latter parts of the match because I was injured in the very first over of the New Zealand second innings when I dived forward to take a catch at slip off Zaheer’s bowling. The edge from Tim McIntosh had come low and as I tried to get my fingers under the ball I damaged the index finger of my left hand. I had to be taken to hospital to have the injury checked and X-rays revealed I had a fracture.

There wasn’t much time before the second Test at Napier but the early end of the first one at least gave me an extra day to recover. To protect the finger, I tried putting three finger caps one on top of the other and also applied a fibre plaster, which I moulded by putting it in hot water, topped off with a lot of padding. With all that protection, I had little sense of where my finger actually was, but in the end I decided I could last a Test as long as I stood in a relatively quiet fielding position.

This time it worked out well and I managed to score runs in both innings of the second Test at Napier. New Zealand scored 619 in their first innings, with Jesse Ryder following up his 102 in the first Test with